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5.1 War Begins

Finders keepers. That's what the French might have said when they claimed prime real estate in the Ohio Valley for themselves. But the British and the American colonists begged to differ.

MAIN IDEA Competition for land and furs involved France and Great Britain in many years of war in North America, starting with the French and Indian War.

SEEDS OF CONFLICT

When French fur traders first came to North America in the 1600s, they set up a few forts and **trading posts** in the St. Lawrence Valley. As you may recall, the French traded with the Huron and Algonquian there for almost 100 years. But after French trappers killed many of the animals in the area and fur supplies dwindled, they resettled in the Ohio Valley. This land was also claimed by Great Britain. So in the 1740s, the British joined forces with the Iroquois and pushed the French traders out of the valley.

The fertile land of the Ohio Valley appealed to colonial settlers. In 1749, they were eager to buy land shares from the Ohio Company of Virginia, which promoted the westward settlement of colonists from Virginia. But the French hadn't given up their claim to the land. They built a number of forts there, including Fort LeBoeuf (luh-BUHF) in northwest Pennsylvania. Then in 1752, the French destroyed Pickawillany, a colonial trading post. In an effort to settle the dispute over the Ohio Valley peacefully, the British governor of Virginia sent a young colonial army leader named **George Washington** to Fort LeBoeuf to ask the French to leave. Not surprisingly, they refused.

COLONIAL INVOLVEMENT

In 1754, the British decided to take more forceful measures and sent the newly promoted Colonel Washington and a small number of troops to capture Fort Duquesne (doo-KAYN) in present-day Pittsburgh. When he arrived, Washington quickly realized he was outnumbered. Scrambling to defend his troops, he built a wooden barrier, or stockade, which he fittingly named Fort Necessity. But the situation was hopeless. French and Native American troops surrounded the fort and attacked, causing heavy losses for Washington's troops. Defeated, Washington surrendered and abandoned the fort.

Many consider this battle the beginning of the **French and Indian War**. For Britain and France, this war would become part of a larger one, called the Seven Years' War, that officially began in 1756. It pitted these two great powers in a struggle over land in Europe.

The colonists, meanwhile, were concerned with land in North America. Seven colonies sent delegates to a congress in Albany, New York, to discuss uniting the colonies to fight the French for that land. The delegates adopted Benjamin Franklin's **Albany Plan of Union**, which proposed granting a central government the power to tax, pass laws, and oversee military defense for the colonies. When the delegates returned home with the proposal, none of the colonies approved it. But the colonists were united in their determination to fight for land they considered theirs. And they soon persuaded the British to help them.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the fur trade cause conflict between the French and the British?
2. **INTERPRET MAPS** Around what bodies of water were many of the battles fought?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** What was the purpose of the Albany Plan of Union?

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